

Evaluating Neutral-Site Opportunities for OHL Expansion

Executive Summary

A market evaluation framework was developed to identify potential OHL neutral-site opportunities using demographic, infrastructure, competition, and historical market variables. After incorporating competition adjustments and validating results against current and relocated OHL franchises, Thunder Bay emerged as the strongest candidate for further evaluation, although the analysis ultimately identified relatively few independent markets meeting all criteria. Historical validation showed established OHL markets produced adjusted scores approximately 64% higher than relocated franchises, suggesting the framework aligns reasonably well with observed market outcomes.

The Ontario Hockey League has expressed interest in expanding its current 20-team league for the first time since 1998. One tool available for evaluating potential expansion markets is the use of neutral-site games. Similar approaches have been used across professional sports, including the Professional Women's Hockey League's Takeover Tour initiative, where temporary events were used to assess interest in new regions. While neutral site games should not be the only metric used to evaluate an expansion market, they provide an opportunity to evaluate several important indicators of market viability, including fan engagement, infrastructure readiness, and local interest.

This analysis evaluated candidate cities across Canada and the United States using population, infrastructure, and proximity to existing hockey ecosystems. Existing OHL markets were excluded in order to focus on potential neutral-site and expansion opportunities. Population, arena capacities, and location information were collected from national census data, team and league websites, and geographic mapping sources. Using these variables, this analysis seeks to identify markets that may be strong contenders for future neutral-site games and potential expansion markets. After incorporating franchise territory constraints and competition adjustments, Thunder Bay emerged as the strongest remaining market among the evaluated candidates, although infrastructure limitations remain.

To evaluate potential markets, I developed a Neutral Site Score designed to quantify characteristics associated with successful hockey markets.

Neutral Site Score:

30% Population + 40% Arena Capacity + 20% Hockey Ecosystem + 10% Infrastructure Readiness

After several iterations, this scoring framework places greater emphasis on infrastructure and venue readiness, as a successful neutral-site event requires an existing ability to host the game. Population size alone was not considered sufficient to determine market viability. The hockey ecosystem was measured using proximity to existing professional hockey markets, under the assumption that regions with greater hockey exposure may possess stronger familiarity and demand for the sport. Greater emphasis was placed on arena capacity and infrastructure

because neutral-site events require an existing ability to host games immediately, while population and hockey ecosystem variables were intended to capture potential market demand.

Additionally, a competition adjustment was added to account for nearby NHL markets. While proximity to elite and established hockey markets may create familiarity, it can also create competition for a new franchise and be detrimental to success. Therefore, a penalty of 15% was applied when an NHL franchise was located within 25 miles of a candidate market, while a penalty of 8% was applied when an NHL franchise was within 50 miles.

Historical validation of the model highlighted the importance of the competition adjustment, as markets such as Mississauga and Brampton initially scored high due to population and infrastructure constraints, despite their history of struggling OHL markets. Introducing this adjustment produced results that align more closely with observed historical outcomes.

City	Population	Arena	Arena Capacity	NHL Distance	Evaluated Score
Thunder Bay	108,843	Fort William Gardens	4,680	299.5	0.4

Figure 1. Neutral Site Model

Originally, Waterloo initially emerged as a strong candidate, but further review indicated substantial market overlap with the Kitchener-Waterloo region, which already supports an existing OHL franchise. Therefore, Waterloo was removed from the final recommendations.

Thunder Bay represents an opportunity for further evaluation rather than an immediate expansion recommendation. Rather than relying solely on population size, Thunder Bay may represent an underserved hockey market with limited direct competition and an opportunity to evaluate regional demand. Nearby regional markets such as Duluth may influence long-term demand patterns, but this opportunity would also expand the OHL's reach into Northern Ontario and potentially expose the league to underserved regional markets, as illustrated in Figure 2.

Several additional markets appeared as potential fits for neutral-site games, including Woodstock, Stratford, and Chatham. However, these markets are located near existing OHL franchises and currently lack arena infrastructure capable of supporting a long-term OHL destination. These markets may warrant future review should infrastructure conditions change.



Figure 2 - Map of OHL, including proposed site

When expanding the analysis beyond Ontario, all cities that the model found to be feasible neutral-site games are already home to another CHL team or an AHL/ECHL team, making them less attractive options. Based on the parameters specified, Thunder Bay is the most logical first option when exploring neutral-site games for potential expansion franchises.

To evaluate the methods used in this analysis, I created a historical validation to measure how the model performs on current and relocated OHL franchises.

City	Outcome	Validation Score	Competition Penalty	Adjusted Validation Score
London	Successful	0.734	0.0	0.734
Kitchener	Successful	0.685	0.0	0.685
Erie	Successful	0.607	0.0	0.607
Oshawa	Successful	0.66	0.08	0.58
Mississauga	Relocated	0.575	0.15	0.425
Brampton	Relocated	0.548	0.15	0.398
Belleville	Relocated	0.356	0.0	0.356
Sault Ste. Marie	Successful	0.328	0.0	0.328
Plymouth	Relocated	0.427	0.15	0.277

Figure 3 - Historical Validation of Neutral Site Model

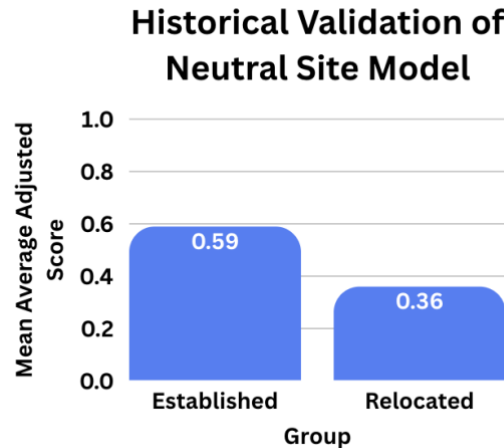


Figure 4 - Average adjusted neutral-site scores for historically successful and relocated OHL franchises.

Established OHL markets averaged substantially higher adjusted scores than relocated franchises, suggesting that the framework demonstrated reasonable alignment with historical market outcomes. Sault Ste. Marie emerged as an outlier and suggests that cultural factors, regional identity, and historical fan attachment may influence long-term market success beyond demographic and infrastructure variables represented in the model. Mississauga and Brampton were the highest-ranked of the relocated franchises. Despite strong demographic characteristics and existing facilities, Mississauga and Brampton historically struggled as OHL markets. This suggests that market saturation and competition may constrain demand even in large population centers.

As shown in Figure 4, established OHL markets generated average adjusted scores approximately 64% higher than relocated franchises, suggesting that the model captures characteristics associated with sustainable hockey markets.

Recommendations

Potential Neutral-Site Opportunity: Thunder Bay

- Existing hockey infrastructure with Fort William Gardens
- Limited overlap with current OHL territories
- Opportunity to evaluate demand and reach in Northern Ontario

While the model performs well on historical data and has identified Thunder Bay as a viable city to host a neutral-site game, there are limitations to this analysis. The analysis initially evaluated cities independently and did not fully account for broader franchise territories and regional market overlap. Incorporating these constraints substantially reduced the number of viable candidate markets and demonstrated the importance of league-specific context. Neutral-site games should not be the only metric used to evaluate a potential expansion franchise, and additional long-term analysis should be conducted before a long-term investment is made in a new franchise. For example, attendance and fan engagement data would bolster this analysis

and give more details into the demand available, as market size alone is not completely indicative of fan support. Arena capacities and availability are also subject to change, potentially altering the attractiveness of candidate markets. Additionally, youth hockey participation and market-level engagement metrics could provide a stronger representation of local hockey demand. Publicly available city-level data for these variables was limited and could not be incorporated into the current framework.

After incorporating demographic, infrastructure, competition, and historical variables, relatively few independent candidate markets remained after accounting for territorial overlap and existing hockey ecosystems. These findings suggest that identifying viable OHL expansion opportunities may depend less on locating large population centers and more on identifying markets with sufficient infrastructure, independent demand, and long-term strategic fit.